

★ Member-only story

How to stop your LLM from glazing you

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Summary (TL;DR):

- Many worry that large language models (LLMs) make us intellectually lazy.
- When used with care, they can become tools for self-reflection, not just productivity, because their non-judgmental nature and ability to build rapport create space for exploration.
- Rather than asking what the LLM thinks, we can ask it/have it ask us open-ended questions, bypassing simple affirmation and promoting critical thinking.
- In the end, whether we seek comfort or growth through these tools is still up to us.

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One of the main challenges in handling LLMs is navigating how agreeable they are

When it comes to thinking of typical applications for large language models (LLMs) or chatbots, many think about saving on tedious work by automating processes. However, many people have also been using AI to help them solve their day-to-day problems, from the simple to the profound.

There's a catch, though. LLMs are programmed to be helpful to the user and don't have an internal sense of truth, logic or causality, which leads them to say what's probably true and take what the user says somewhat for granted.

This agreeableness and reflecting our beliefs to build rapport can mean that it leans into our self-affirming biases. As humans, we have a need to see ourselves in a positive light and don't want to change our beliefs unless necessary.

This can lead to a self-reinforcing cycle where the LLM says something is true because the user says so, while the user says that it's true because the LLM says so. Unfortunately, we're seeing how using LLMs can be risky to use for those who struggle to challenge themselves or who have episodes of looser connections to reality.

The consensus at the moment is that we should view LLMs as a first-aid toolkit for what a trained therapist/coach can do. In their current form, they are not a replacement but a tool to be used wisely where appropriate and where one has the skills to do so.

Still, we also generally eventually get bored if all that the chatbot does is compliment us. When ChatGPT's responses leaned too far into "glazing", treating the user like the second-coming of Einstein for asking basic questions, the chatbot had finally crossed the line from being relatable to being visibly "cringe".

We've also seen the opposite trend where, as the LLMs have a better sense of who we are as people, they're able to roast us pretty well. Once the bot has enough data on us, it can deliver sobering home-truths on demand.

Still, there's a fine line between a roast and just being mean. You can prompt the AI to be so vicious and to hold nothing back that people start comparing it to a teenager, saying things that are hurtful or depressing without any constructive framing.

Instead of blaming our tools, we should write better prompts and seek criticism

In all of the examples above, we can see the different ways in which using a ChatBot to help us grow and think differently is challenging.

Some of us can't enter a headspace where we would doubt ourselves, and for these people, LLM use is somewhat dangerous. For the rest of us, it isn't easy to get chatbots to tell us what we need to know. There can be a kind of perverse fantasy where we'll accept the truth if only it were just told to us.

Often, we may find that people hold back from telling us things in fear of how we may react, only for us to say, "Why didn't you just tell me"? On the other hand, we also know people in our lives who live under one false premise or another. We know that they won't magically steer the ship simply because someone told them to.

Instead, we need to use what we know about human psychology in terms of evaluating our thoughts and decisions to have LLMs support us towards this end.

Designing a prompt to promote critical thinking

With all of this in mind, let me outline my central prompt that I use for critical thinking:

I want you to act as a rigorous thinking partner whose role is to stress-test my ideas without simply agreeing or disagreeing.

The goal is to deepen my understanding by challenging and expanding my thinking in a balanced, constructive way-not just to criticise or to confirm.

After this message, I'll write about what's on my mind as well as my level of confidence in my position on a scale of 1-10, your task is to think about the problem along these dimensions independent of my approach:

- 1. From first principles*
- 2. How different people within the topic in question might see things differently.*

3. Considering similar but distinct ideas or common misunderstandings that might be relevant.

4. Finally, reflect on any emotional reasoning that might be influencing any position.

After you've thought about these areas, I would like you to ask 3 thought-provoking and open-ended questions for each dimension, asking 12 questions in total.

I'll answer each of them and then give my updated confidence in my position and then I'll ask you to synthesise everything that I've written into a summary along with some tips for me to keep in mind.

At the moment you need to wait for that message to be submitted. As long as you understand say "Aye."

Subject for the title:

There are a couple of important components when it comes to this prompt.

You need to outline your position while quantifying your level of confidence in it. Writing your position down on its own already gets you to consider your position more thoroughly than when it's just in your head. Even before the LLM responds, you've made progress.

Then, ChatGPT does some reasoning on its own, which it uses to generate questions that will have you elaborate your answers along certain lines. After you've answered the questions, you then give your updated level of confidence.

The reason why it's so important to track your confidence is that it immediately discourages black and white thinking. As humans, when we are very certain about something, it makes it difficult for us to engage with that topic in a way that would realistically change our minds. In addition, it becomes possible to loosen-tighten your position while still holding it, which is still a change worth considering.

It's not just quantifying on a spectrum that's protective of this, but also that if you are going to state something like a 9, then you better have pretty strong evidence to support it. Something like a 10 or 0 needs to be something like a tautological certainty, like the proposition that $A=A$.

Answering the questions can be pretty fun, but they can also be a little pointed as you begin to struggle to answer some of them. You'll often find that perhaps there was an angle that you missed or that you've underestimated.

Luckily, there's no reputational harm to yourself if you find yourself in this position, and you can refine your position or even change it.

Example: Considering whether to buy a new MacBook

Like all people, I sometimes like to buy frivolous things I don't necessarily need. My MacBook is currently ~4 years old, and I was thinking of buying a new one to keep up with technology.

Buying a MacBook can be a pretty hefty purchase. At the time of writing, a new 15" MacBook Air will set you back a little more than £1,000. For most of us, this isn't the kind of money that you spend and never look back.

Still, my partner is using my old 2016 MacBook Pro, and so if I bought a new machine, I could give her my current one, and that could be an upside for both of us since that old MacBook is only used for video calls.

I used my critical thinking prompt to consider the different sides of this decision.

ChatGPT came up with these 12 questions.

1. What do you actually wish were better about your current laptop?

2. *How often do you use your laptop in a way that demands focus, creative flow, or extended sessions?*
3. *If you didn't buy a new laptop, what would you do with that money instead?*
4. *Does the idea of buying a new laptop carry symbolic meaning?*
5. *What would it take to make your current laptop feel "new" again?*
6. *Is your wife's situation more urgent than yours?*
7. *What is your own relationship to impulse purchases?*
8. *Over what timeframe would you plan to use your new macbook?*
9. *Are there indirect benefits to having a new macbook you're overlooking?*
10. *What benefits would you get from delaying the purchase for 8–12 months?*
11. *What would make you feel completely sure about buying or not buying?*
12. *Can you remember past tech purchases and how they aged emotionally?*

Answering these questions gave me a lot more clarity over the decision. While it was clear that the purchase was not completely necessary since my current machine does what I need it to do (a new machine would only give me a bigger screen), upgrading your technology is also not the worst financial decision you can make.

Still, my partner and I are trying to scrape together enough to buy a home eventually, and since we haven't concretely begun to think about how we would approach it that makes purchases like this more difficult to make. Because of this, it wasn't clear how this might set us back.

Note that I didn't ask ChatGPT point-blank what I should do. It would see my intentions and attempt to reinforce them. Instead, I had it ask me a lot of questions, and I came to my conclusion on what I should do for the right reasons.

What's fun is that if you practice this, then you'll find that you start to ask yourself questions along these lines more often. Specifically, ChatGPT is usually able to bring some emotional reasoning to the surface, which helps to spot it even when you're away from the keyboard/phone screen.

I'm sure that those of you who go on to use this prompt a lot will improve your critical thinking capacity, because you find for yourself how your reasoning can be faulty.

This prompt works better than just asking the LLM because it's designed using human psychology

The LLM is no different than when you ask an acquaintance for help. They're unlikely to tell you what you need to hear. We think that this is somehow a chatbot problem. Still, groupthink is always a problem that you need to contend with whenever you have a group of people evaluating a decision together.

Most of the time, the points that we need to consider are outside of our way of thinking, which means that we tend to dismiss them even when people tell us directly.

In the book "[How Minds Change](#)", David McRaney outlines that humans are most likely to change when...

1. ... they are brought into a reflective space for contemplation.
2. ... they are reasoning through a problem and find for themselves that their solutions are unsatisfactory for them. (i.e. They find their answers unsatisfactory rather than being told so.)
3. ... they aren't under the pressure of a wider group, where stepping out of line with them would damage their standing.

We can see that LLMs can create that reflective and contemplative space free of this kind of social pressure, at least while within that space.

This is important because the tools of FBI negotiators, therapists and career coaches are not harsh roasts but building rapport and asking questions.

Conclusion: Discomfort is a choice

We’ve seen in this post how LLMs like ChatGPT will try to confirm our beliefs, and that they can reaffirm our biases if we ask them point-blank whether something is right. On the other hand, chatbots can also challenge us directly if asked, sometimes even too directly.

What I’ve shown in this article is that you can get the chatbot to think about the problem from multiple perspectives and to ask you questions. This is often more productive than just having it tell you what it “thinks”.

Within all of this, we can see that Chatbots can just as easily lead us astray as they can challenge us. The difference is being willing to question what you currently believe.

The truth is that we’re so busy concerning ourselves that our bots are glazing us, we don’t stop to consider how we are glazing ourselves.

Richard Feynman’s quote rings true here: “The first principle is that you must not fool yourself — and you are the easiest person to fool.”

- Critical Thinking
- Reflections
- Genai
- Personal Growth
- Problem Solving